

What is research? The academic nature of research

Advanced Diploma

Lecture 2, 10 February 2020

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Housekeeping

- Blackboard
 - RME477S (PT & FT)
- Register
- Lesson topic plan
- Learning resources
 - Basics
 - *Additional readings*
- Loadshedding

Learning Resources

MAIN TEXTBOOK

(Kumar, R 2011)

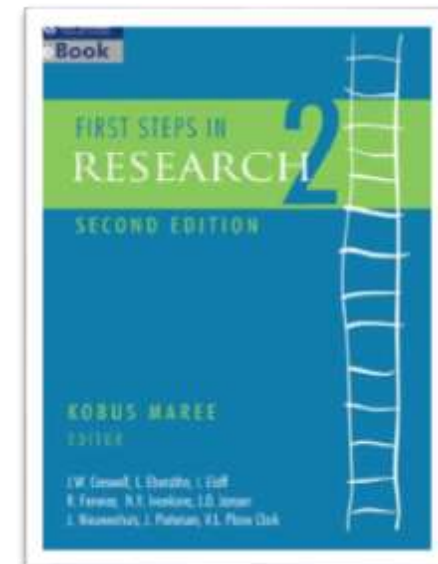
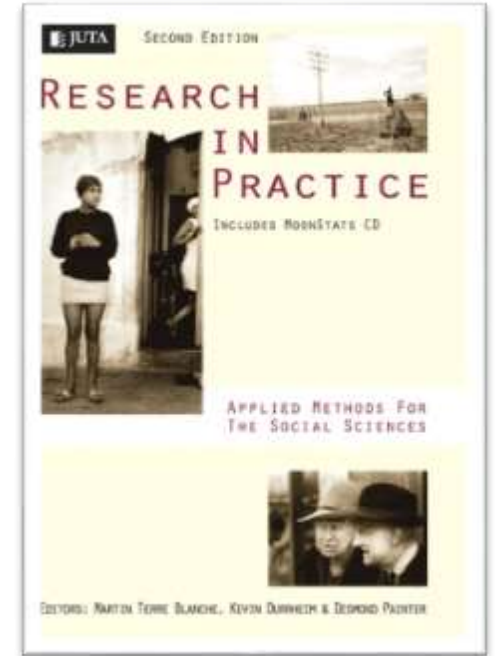
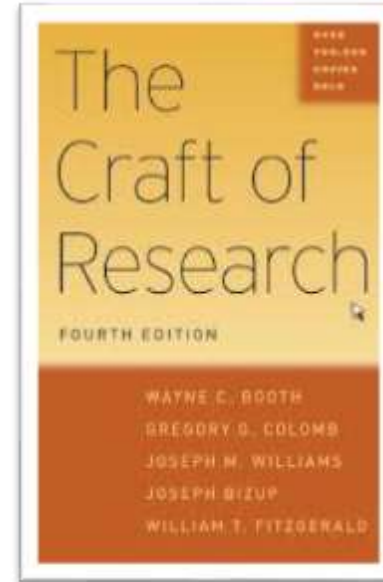
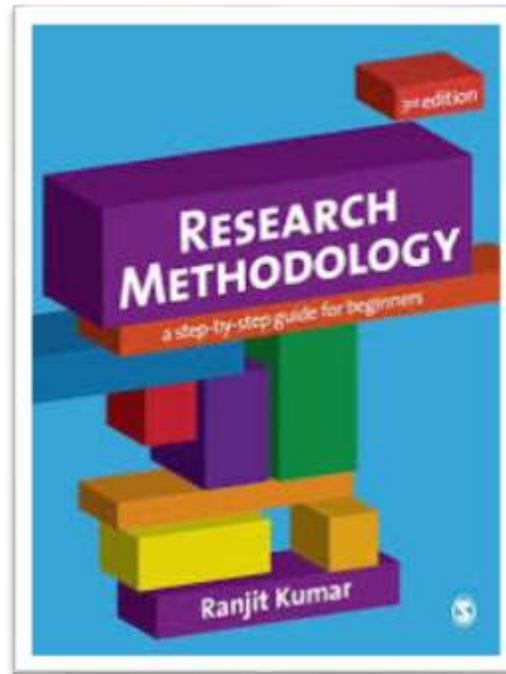
SUPPLEMENTARY TEXTBOOKS

Booth et al, 2016

Terre Blanche et al, 2006

Blaxter et al, 2006

Maree, 2016



Week	Dates	Lesson Topic or Learning Activity	Readings
TERM 1			
1	3 - 7 Feb	Welcome and orientation to subject (What do researchers 'look like and do?')	Subject Guide
2	9 - 13 Feb	What is research? Nature of academic research	Booth et al (2016) Chapter 1 <i>Kumar (2011) Chapter 1</i>
3	16 - 20 Feb	What is research? Characteristics and types of research	Kumar (2011) - Chapter 1
4	23 - 27 Feb	Research activities – processes, procedures and activities associated with research	Blaxter et al (2006) - Chapter 1 Kumar - Chapter 2
5	2 - 6 Mar	Conducting ethical research. Becoming an ethical researcher	Terre Blanche et al (2006) Chapter 4 Booth et al (2016) The Ethics of research
6	9 - 13 Mar	EXAM PREP	
7	16 - 20 Mar	TEST WEEK	

QUESTIONS

Subject Guide?

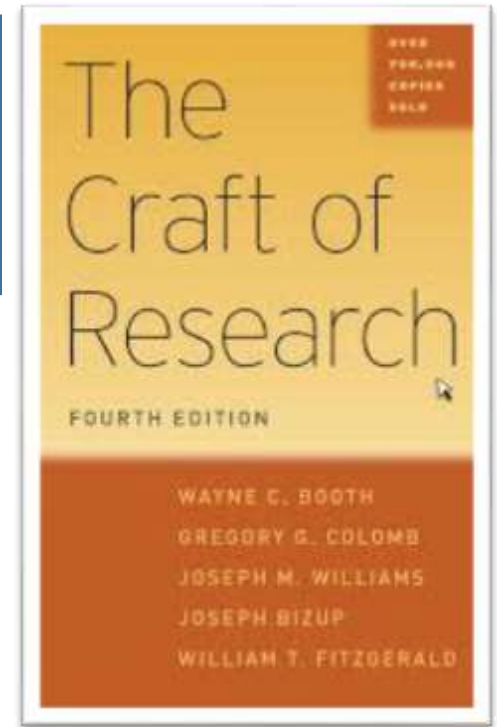


Thinking in Print (Booth et al)

- What is the chapter about?
- What is the main point that the authors make?
- What are some of the key words and phrases in the chapter (that help you to make sense of what the authors the saying)
- Why is writing such a fundamental aspects of academic research?
- What are some of the standard written forms/genres associated with academic research?
- Can you think of 'other' forms of research/information gathering/knowledge you have used? What is different about how that knowledge is shared/communicated when compared with academic/scientific research?

Thinking in Print

- Research about the publication/communication of trustworthy inquiry
- Research can happen in many different places
- About developing a sceptical and questioning disposition
- Writing and publication of research is fundamental to research
 - Standard and traditional forms that signal the academic/scientific location of the research
 - Research paper, journal article, research report, conference papers, books, book chapters



Writing is thinking

- ‘thinking with and for your readers’

‘disentangle your ideas from your memories and wishes, so that you – and others – can explore, expand, combine and understand them more fully’ (Booth et al, 2016:14)



Comfort break

What is (academic/scientific) research?

- A way of thinking: examining critically the various aspects of your day-to-day professional work
- A habit of questioning what you do
- Systematic examination to explain and find answers
- Understanding, formulating guiding principles that govern a particular procedure
- Developing and testing theories that contribute to a discipline or profession

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graph LR; A[Asking question(s)] --> B[Systematic examination]; B --> C[Arriving at valid answer(s)];
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Asking
question(s)

Systematic
examination

Arriving at
valid answer(s)

Research can be conducted in many ways

Scientific or academic research

1. Undertaken within a framework of a set of philosophies

Each discipline brings different approaches to how they 'see the world' and how they investigate and approach research

2. Uses procedures, methods, techniques that are valid & reliable

Correct procedures applied

Quality of measurement that provides repeatability and accuracy

3. Designed to be unbiased and objective



- **Biomedical Science**

- One truth (one answer)
- Test a theory or model
- Control variables
- Experimental method – test impact of variables
- In laboratory or controlled environment
- No researcher bias/subjectivity



- **Ethnography (Social Anthropology, Education)**

- Humans living in society
- Real life context
- Don't control variables (account for their influence)
- Researcher can be part of the research (is a valid source of information)
- Multiple forms of data collected/generated
- Use theory to explain data not to 'prove' the theory

What can be called research?

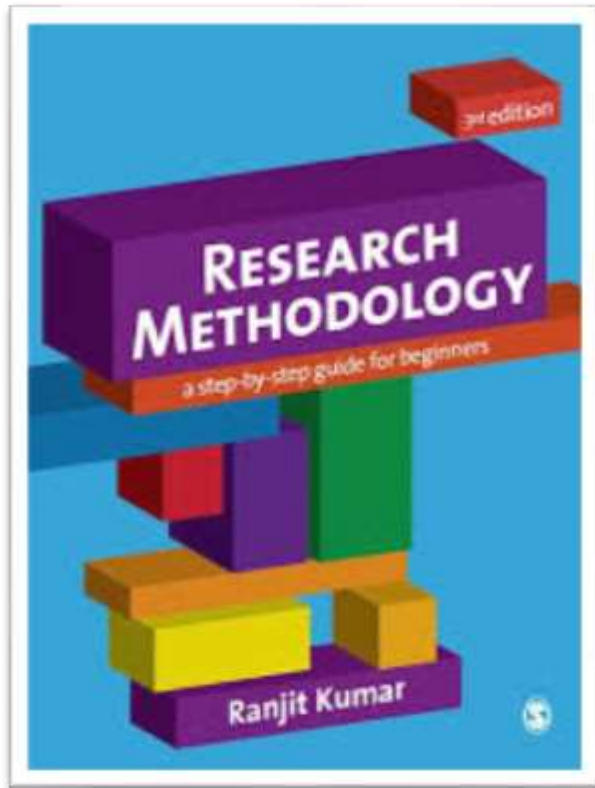
- Fulfil certain **requirements**
- Have certain **characteristics**

A process for collecting, analysing and interpreting information to answer questions

1. *Controlled*
2. *Rigorous*
3. *Systematic*
4. *Valid & verifiable*
5. *Critical scrutiny*

NEXT WEEK

- Kumar – Chapter 1



- Definitions
 - Find the key definitions of research described in the chapter?
 - Re-write these in your own words?
 - What are the different requirements/characteristics of research? Explain each element in your own words?
- Types of research
 - Identify the different types of research
 - Provide definitions in your own words for each type